

On July 21, the Guild chair told me to provide notes on my job performance recently:

Since I acknowledged receiving that memorandum from sports editor Chris Thomas in early March, I have continued to excel on the beat.

In my first assignment back on the beat in early March, I went to the Dominican Republic and wrote a pair of unique feature stories. When I arrived to spring training, baseball was canceled. In early June - with the help of my editors, including Thomas - I completed a project on the Armando Galarraga near-perfect game that Thomas said he feels has a good chance to place in the Associated Press Sports Editors contest next year. On July 2, I received an exclusive look at Tigers superstar Miguel Cabrera working out — Cabrera has not been available to the media once in summer camp. Last week, I talked to Daniel Norris about his experience with the coronavirus — no other reporter did.

I feel very confident in saying that I have a stranglehold on the beat I cover, from reporting to writing to breaking news to sourcing to social media. On July 10, the Tigers announced that they were live-streaming the remainder of their intra-squad games. My tweet on the topic received 120 retweets and 731 likes — three times as many as the rest of my competitors combined. In every aspect, it is not close.

In addition, over the past year, I have been working on a sensitive story about the Tigers business side. I have talked to over 30 people for this story and have made great strides in my reporting. As recently as a month ago, I was knocking on people's doors and talking with them in their backyard. I have written stories about Ilitch Holdings and pursued angles both inside and out of my assigned beat aggressively. This kind of reporting is perceived by the Tigers as a threat and there is great incentive in removing the biggest voice on the beat.

On many occasions, I have filed embargoed stories ahead of time so that our website can receive early traffic. Examples of this include: No. 1 overall pick Spencer Torkelson being drafted as a third baseman - I had a story pre-written on the website at the time of the pick; multiple draft picks early; the team's full schedule and impending coronavirus announcements two days before they were released.

Though I feel my working relationship with direct management has improved significantly since November, as Thomas noted in a March memo, it has felt like their decisions, demands and communication since November have put me in a position to fail. When Thomas informed me that I was keeping my assignment in February, he made clear that "If you don't improve, this is your last year," and to "not fuck it up," which made me feel uncomfortable.

One of the areas of improvement that Thomas outlined in a memo that I didn't sign was growing page views by 10% over the previous year. Though this was not included in the memo that I ultimately received, signifying an agreement on job expectations, it is notable because of the industry-wide initiative for clicks. After I was told that I was keeping my assignment, Thomas sent a Lions reporter to cover spring training for nearly two weeks as the primary reporter while I

did nothing at home. Traditionally - especially for a losing team like the Tigers - web hits are plentiful in spring training.

Also in this time I have not been written up or disciplined or anything like that.

On July 25, I e-mailed the Guild chair and provided her with instances that I felt may have been brought up by the Tigers to the Free Press in support of their decision.

I don't know if you need any of this, but like I said, I talked to someone in the know and - this probably doesn't surprise you - but it's likely that the two sides are working together, i.e., the Tigers providing the Free Press with text messages and information to support their decision.

So I decided to be proactive and identify some of the things they might bring up, so you have background information to put these communications in context. I would describe myself as an aggressive reporter who uses all of the information on hand at my disposal in cultivating sources. I am not afraid of pushing sources out of their comfort zone to get what I need but I also stay within the rules while riding the fence.

Thank you for the time and the continued help with this. I also have screenshots I can provide with you and have so many more questions after reading the contract last night. Enjoy the weekend.

Anthony

— Last spring, I wrote a weekly “Letters from Spring Training” column which served as a personalized, behind-the-scenes look at a reporter in spring training. Toward the end of the spring, I had found out that one of the team’s PR guys, Ben Fidelman, was telling others over dinner that, “I want to end Fenech.” On March 10, 2019, I texted Fidelman a screenshot with this excerpt highlighted: “Apparently one of the staffers was plotting my demise after I brought it too light. I don’t need to plot his demise: I’m sure the players would be thrilled to know he is the nephew of the man who is taking money out of their pockets.”

I sent a follow-up text saying, “I’m gonna let this slide for now but watch yo’self”

— My expianation: I was offended that Fidelman would try to undermine my reporting ability by speaking about me in front of other team employees and baseball operations officials in such a manner and I wanted to send a message. He approached me weeks later, claiming that I was blackmailing him, which I strongly disputed. He has told people throughout his career that he is the nephew of MLB commissioner Rob Manfred, which he denied to me that day.

— On Aug. 24, 2019, I sent these text messages to general manager Al Avila after I had learned from another source that a player was coming up.

“Is Castro coming up?”

“Another one you told PR to announce so I couldn’t break it”

“Just like Fulmer”

“Another trade is coming out Sunday”

Shortly thereafter, in an attempt to remedy my approach, I said, “Hey, taking a step back. Been a long week for me personally and professionally. I understand our relationship has changed and I am not going to go scorched earth on you every time you don’t help me out anymore like you have in the past. Thank you for getting back to me earlier, have a good day.”

— My explanation: My relationship with Avila has been wide-ranging and a give-and-take understanding had been clearly established at that time. Because I wrote a critical story at the beginning of the month, it had changed. Though I did not explicitly state that I heard Castro was coming up from a source in an attempt to protect that person’s identity, I was frustrated that I brought news to him and he was unable to confirm it. That March, I brought a similar situation to Avila’s attention regarding a major surgery with one of the Tigers’ players. He notified the PR department to send the announcement out so I could not get the scoop.

By saying, “Another trade is coming out Sunday,” I was intimating that I would report on another trade that the Tigers passed on, though I don’t think that can be interpreted as explicit.

— On November 25, 2019, when I was heading into a meeting with Chris Thomas and Peter Bhatia which resulted in my first re-assignment, I learned from a source that the Tigers were working on a trade for Pittsburgh’s Dario Agrazal. I receive this information from people in the Tigers’ front office, which I then bring to Avila to get it confirmed.

At 11:07 a.m., I said, “Are you going to make any news in the next two hours? Heading into a meeting with my bosses, don’t want to be caught off guard” to put it on his radar. After the meeting, I had a text message from the source saying the deal was close to completed.

At 12:10 p.m., I texted Avila saying, “I’m not covering the Tigers anymore. You better give me the scoop for whatever you’re working on” and “I’m not happy about it at all and I want to stick it to them.”

Avila called me shortly thereafter but did not disclose the details of the trade for reporting.

At 1:13 p.m., not willing to wait for Avila’s confirmation any longer, I tweeted the news out based on the reporting from my previous source — which was accurate and counted as the news break for the story.

At 1:18 p.m., Avila texted me back with Agrazal’s name — the story was already reported.

— My explanation: Likewise, the Tigers will likely argue that I’m using undue leverage to obtain my scoops. “You better give me the scoop for whatever you’re working on” is close, but I didn’t expressly say that I was going to do anything in retaliation if he didn’t. It probably wasn’t a good idea to say I wanted to stick it to my bosses, but I judged my relationship with Avila as a private one.

— On July 16 at 1:04 p.m., I texted Tigers assistant general manager David Chadd, saying, “Y’all are just going gonna stand around while (employee’s last name) works on sticking a knife in Al’s back huh”

I have been told that Chadd ran this text message up the ladder and that Sartori has been informed about it, and also that Tigers Vice President of communications Ron Colangelo has been seeking text messages to help the Free Press further illustrate that I should be removed from the beat.

— My explanation: I did this because I had heard sufficient information over the years that Sartori was trying to undermine Avila’s power by communicating closely with Tigers ownership. I heard a more substantive account shortly before I sent that text, when I decided to start digging by striking a nerve with Chadd. I know that Chadd and Sartori do not like each other, I am comfortable with where the information I received came from, and I was trying to lead Chadd into providing me with information that would lead me closer to my reporting end goal.

Yesterday night, I sent the Guild chair this e-mail about my situation. On July 29, the executive editor confirmed to the Guild that I was in the reporter classification. This was pretty much their biggest argument, in terms of filing a grievance. I don’t think there is a grievance anymore, I’m just going to get disciplined somehow.

Hey, I just wanted to give you guys an update on where I’m at on this whole thing. Consider this information on background and not for distribution, confidential, between us, all of that.

Last night, Chris e-mailed out a schedule for the next two weeks. It has me listed as GA 8-12 on Monday, OFF on Tuesday and Wednesday, GA 8-12 on Thursday and Friday and NASCAR on Saturday and Sunday. For the next week, I am listed as SNow 8-12 from Monday through Friday.

I’m interpreting “SNow” as “SportsNow,” like a spin-off of the FreepNow team. This is how Peter described FreepNow in a July 2 staff memo:

“The times inevitably involve some ambiguity. We are a newsroom that must be driven by unique, revelatory content, but we also have an excellent FreepNow operation that is breaking news online as it happens constantly. We aren’t consumed by crime news, but we cover what we must. Detroit and Michigan always provides an assortment of whacky stories and we’d be foolish to ignore them. We make our reputation and stake our credibility on our deep-dive work. We take the page-view gifts because our audience looks to us for it and it gives us runway to do the important work. And we are showing longer-form excellent investigations and enterprise attract audience and engaged time. Yes, there is some conflict there, but as long as we remain thoughtful about what we are doing and don’t go off the rails, I have confidence in our decision-

making. Perfection and journalism are rarely in the same sentence, but let's talk when you think we aren't living up to our stated goals.”

This description is very similar to the work they do on the sports web desk, a blurred line of reporting and aggregating, which appears to be the card they are playing in re-assigning me.

When I saw that Chris e-mailed the schedule, I got anxious. When I opened it like 10 minutes later, I got really anxious and even angry. Not only am I down for SNow, but I'm also down for NASCAR next weekend. So it looks like Tanya's e-mail to Peter didn't factor into a “fair” schedule. (I am aware that they may have ways around it.) From this perspective, I think it's crap that they can tell me that I'm re-assigned to the web desk and can work remotely but then have the ability to bring me back on a whim. But it is what it is.

Either way, I have made the decision not to work in Sports anymore. I've spent all week reliving the last three years in these notes and there is no way I'm going to put myself anywhere near that situation again. I'm done feeling like that. It is so bad that I'm not willing to work one more second under him: I don't want to have any more communication with him and I don't want to put myself in a position where I can say something that can jeopardize my employment if I do.

Since around the time I received the schedule last night, I haven't felt good, both physically and mentally. I just woke up in cold sweats and got sick. These symptoms are likely to continue throughout the night and into the morning, at which time I will e-mail Chris to inform him that I am sick and I cannot work Monday's GA shift from 12-8.

Again, I am done with it. He is not healthy for me. The only reason this lasted two weeks was because he was on furlough. Even if I didn't talk to him at all and Kirkland gave me assignments, I'm still part of the “web desk chat” with the others and I don't want to see his name or hear his thoughts.

The only reason I will go back on this decision is if Stevie tells me it is completely and utterly stupid. At one point over the weekend, I suggested to Tanya that I could say that my girlfriend fell down the stairs and I had to take her to the hospital or something and so I had to leave work. She advised against it — that idea was probably completely and utterly stupid. The big difference is that Chris - who I view like a disease - was not around that day. After Monday, I have two off-days. Peter indicated that this would be wrapped up by mid-week. (I am aware that he has been known to drag his feet on such issues.)

I decided two things this weekend: 1.) I'm not working with Chris anymore and 2.) The truth is going to come out. All things considered, I do not have a long-term future at the Free Press. I don't particularly want to work there anymore and I definitely don't want to cover the Tigers anymore. Besides the obvious (money and healthcare), the only thing I'm interested in doing at the Free Press anymore is finishing the investigative story. I understand that may not be possible at this point but I think it is important for me to at least put the information I have on Peter's plate prior to any disciplinary meeting — I do not think he knows much at all about this story and I think it is a very good story. I also think there is potential in the scenario that he shoos it away.

My current plan is to e-mail him a “dossier” about the investigative story on Tuesday morning. If there is a more official way to do this, like in the disciplinary meeting, please let me know. I don’t want to over-step any bounds but I also want to give him time to review the information and even ask others who have heard about the story about their thoughts.

Essentially, I am trying to leverage this story into time to finish it. I understand that I may not necessarily be in a position to leverage anything, but I need something in it for me if I’m going to keep going. If that’s not possible, then I’m willing to consider any kind of a settlement so we can go our separate ways.

I am not educated on the settlement process: Tanya mentioned it to me over the weekend when I told her that I thought they were trying to keep me in Sports in this role under Chris because they know I’d go crazy and just quit. Any information on that would be useful, especially if it can include something that keeps me on healthcare for an extended period of time.

For clarity, while I say the investigative story is the only thing I’m interested in doing anymore, I am not entirely against a scenario in which I am re-assigned to another position in the newsroom (say, breaking news reporter), but with my assignments and time mostly devoted to the story. For example, if they said, three days a week on this assignment and two days on the breaking news desk, I’d seriously consider that because I think this story is important and I feel responsible for seeing it to the finish line with all the time and trust people have given me. It would be a better ending than the pizza. I’m also content if this the end — I think I’ve clearly earned the opportunity with the work I’ve done and if not, I’ve been ready to move on for some time now.

But while I’ve had limited interactions with Peter, I don’t trust him, either, and I’m not sure I’d be comfortable signing up for a scenario in which they can switch my assignments around and ultimately not give me the time that I need to work on the story. I doubt it’s possible to get anything in writing. My first preference would be for all of my time to be devoted to that story.

Personally, there is nothing they can do to make this situation right. Though I still firmly believe I will succeed in this industry in some form, they’ve put me in a really bad position. Twice now, I’ve been re-assigned, just disappearing from the readers with no explanation. While I’m confident in how they the readers view my coverage, it’s really embarrassing and humiliating. I feel like they keep dragging me through the mud - forcing me to put my byline on these click-bait stories and asking me to compile audio stories for the Lions beat writer. I can’t count how many texts I’ve gotten, asking why I’m writing about Adrian College football or the Pistons’ uniforms. People tweet and e-mail me every day. While I certainly have the ability to provide that explanation, I don’t think that’s my responsibility. So, yeah, screw them. I think I’ve been wronged, big time.

Another thing Tanya brought up is how I’m incredibly underpaid and expected to work around-the-clock without having the ability to put down for overtime. To my knowledge, I haven’t been able to put in for OT since I was re-classified from the web desk to a reporter in Nov. 2014. I have never put in OT in this role. Obviously, if there’s any way I could receive additional compensation, I’m all for it.

If there is another way to remedy my current sickness - if the Guild can provide a “doctor’s note,” let’s say, that I can’t work for Chris anymore - instead of calling in sick, let me know. Obviously, I have extensive notes on how we got to this point, but I do want to stress that I would prefer those notes not be handed over to Peter. Given my position, I don’t see the value in sharing that information with him: Sure, I would come back and cover the Tigers if he fired Chris, but I don’t think that’s going to happen.

I do, however, think that the way I have been treated and the situation in which I was re-assigned will raise serious questions about the leadership at the Free Press. I did not come up with those notes for no reason. I absolutely want Peter to see the notes, but I want him to see them on my terms, out in the open for everybody else to see, too, not knowing when it’s coming or what it’s in them. I am not planning on doing anything like this while I am employed at the Free Press and I will be seeking legal counsel before doing anything like this. Though I’m certainly biased, I think the truth will view me favorably and serve as a black eye for them. Also, I feel like I have a lot of strong relationships in the newsroom and that this won’t sit well with them.

As a disclaimer, I’m still not quite sure of how this process goes and the technicalities with it, but I thought this was easiest to convey my thoughts. Obviously, I hope you guys keep fighting for me as much as possible regardless of my stance. I enjoy the fight and I appreciate all the help you’ve given me, especially with reading my pages of rambling about my thoughts on the issue. In a weird way, this has been a lot of fun because I’ve essentially been reporting on a situation that is very personal to me. I have never written this much in life and I’ve enjoyed it. So thank you very much for the time.

Here is a link to the notes on my relationship with Chris. Again, please do not share this with Peter (or anyone else outside the Guild circle of trust for that matter). What I have added since the first version is in bold. Most of the additions are at the bottom and regards the journalistic aspect of the Tigers walking all over him: